

1950–1959

THE COCKTAIL HOUR

With the hard times of World War II behind them, the growing middle class of the 1950s started to respond to the dawn of a new age and live their lives in different ways. Cocktail parties, often held at home, were part of the changing world. The appropriately named cocktail dress, along with a veiled cocktail hat and gloves, were the requisite attire for such gatherings. The formal, mid-calf length dresses of luxurious materials such as velvets and brocades were meant to be worn between the hours of six and eight in the evening. French designer Christian Dior first coined the term “cocktail dress”, and his New Look silhouette defined its romantic style with a tight bodice and full skirt emphasizing the waist. But cocktail dresses were not restricted to the bouffant skirt, and many designers experimented with the narrower sheath style.



1955

Little black dress For this 1955 dress, Madame Grès – a French couture house headed by Germaine Émilie Krebs (also known as Alix Barton) – was inspired by the veiled cocktail hat. Spotted net is draped into an elegant side bustle.



1950



Summer dress French designer Pierre Balmain created this dress for the *jeune fille* (young woman). Its light colour, simple silhouette, and Swiss embroidery imply the innocence of youth. A layered petticoat with a heavily boned bodice creates the ideal shape.

Dior's A-line Dior was inspired by intersecting diagonals for his 1955 Spring/Summer collection, and he aptly named it the A-line. This short evening dress from that collection includes a crossover drape bustier with a gathered skirt creating a bowknot.